

TCE 284 — Writing for Educators

Miami University · Fall 2026

Instructor and logistics

Instructor	Dr. Todd Edwards
Email	edwardm2@miamioh.edu
Office	401H McGuffey Hall
Office hours	Monday, Tuesday, Thursday and Friday, 1:00–3:00 p.m., by appointment. Google Meet by default; the link comes with the booking confirmation. In-person alternative: 401H McGuffey Hall on Mondays and Fridays, Rentschler Library on the Hamilton campus on Tuesdays and Thursdays.
Section	C (CRN 15471)
Class meets	Mondays & Wednesdays, 11:40 a.m.–1:00 p.m., 222 McGuffey Hall
Term	August 24 – December 11, 2026
Textbook	Tom Romano, <i>Write What Matters</i> . The one book, read in order, about a chapter a week across Acts I and II. Chapters are posted in Canvas.
Canvas	https://miamioh.instructure.com/courses/258319
Course home	The public course site carries the schedule, daily outlines, deliverables, policies, and tools. Work is submitted and grades are posted in Canvas.

Term detail. The last Monday/Wednesday meeting is Wednesday, December 2, and the Writer's Notebook is due that day. The course does not meet during finals week (December 7–11), but the Multimodal Research Project is due Wednesday, December 9. Monday, September 7 is Labor Day (no class); Week 3 meets Wednesday only. Fall Break, October 9–11, costs no Monday/Wednesday session.

Course description

TCE 284 is a writing course for future teachers. Students strengthen their own written voice, write across a range of genres, study how successful writers work, respond to each other's drafts, meet one-to-one in conferences, and revise. Everyone in the room is preparing to teach, so the stakes are real: each student will model for a room of children what a writer is and does.

This semester the course writes under one condition. **When a machine can generate fluent prose, images, audio, and video on demand, what is left that only you can do?** We answer that question by making things. AI is not a unit in this course; it is the water we write in. In every act students work alongside it, test it, and learn where it helps and where it hands them the generic version of what they meant to say. The writer's job is the specific, the particular, and the true, which is the one thing an averaging machine cannot manufacture.

The arc of the semester. Three acts, each deepening a single writing gesture, and in each one AI plays a different role.

- **Act I — Become a Writer (Weeks 1–5).** Five short One-Pagers, each a tiny scene from the student's own life plus a reflection on what it means now. Each is drafted in Journaler under a timer, so the writing is theirs by construction. Act I closes with the **Generation Loss lab**: a student presses one of their own pieces through an AI over and over and watches it decay toward the generic. Here AI is a **foil**.
- **Act II — The Currere (Weeks 6–10).** One thread from the student's life, traced across past, present, and an imagined future, then woven into a single piece. Students storyboard it, render its key scenes, meet twice in one-to-one conferences, and revise. Here AI is a **studio tool**: it can help explore and question, but it never writes the student's words.
- **Act III — Multimodal Research Project (Weeks 11–15).** A research project on a topic the student cares about, built from real sources (including one gathered first-hand) and rendered across many forms: writing, image, audio, video. Here AI is a **research partner**, grounded in the student's own sources.

Running underneath all three: the **look-back spine**. In Week 1 students write to the question *why do we write?* In the last week they write a letter back to that Week 1 writer. Reflection on writing actually done is the part of this course a machine cannot fake.

Course objectives

By the end of the course students will be able to:

- Draft with less self-censoring and revise with more purpose, using the habits of practicing writers.
- Write in several genres and adapt voice, form, and structure to subject and audience.
- Read published writing as a writer, naming the craft moves that make it work.
- Give and use honest peer response, and revise across drafts and conferences.
- Compose across modes (writing, image, audio, video) and choose the form a piece needs.
- Use AI deliberately and disclose it honestly, judging where it serves the writing and where it flattens it.
- Reflect on their own writing in a way that no tool can do for them.

Course materials

Required text: Tom Romano, *Write What Matters*. Chapters are posted in Canvas. Additional readings — journal articles, essays, and poems — are linked from the course site or posted in Canvas; there is nothing else to purchase.

Course tools are browser-based; there is nothing to install and no account to create. Any current browser works (Chrome, Edge, Firefox, Safari) on macOS, Windows, Linux, or a Chromebook. A laptop or desktop is recommended, since both the One-Pagers and the Writer's Notebook are turned in by printing to PDF from the browser.

Journaler-284 is the writing app used all term: the timed gush and the five One-Pagers, the currere moments, close reading with highlights and margin notes, and a dated writer's notebook exported as one PDF. It runs entirely in the browser; nothing written is uploaded, and there is no account and no server. Work therefore lives in one browser on one machine — students use ↓ **Save my work** often and keep the file somewhere they own.

Schedule

The course meets Mondays and Wednesdays from August 24 to December 2, 2026. There is no finals-week meeting, but the Multimodal Research Project is due Wednesday, December 9. The Reading column lists what to have read *that* week — readings are assigned the meeting before, so what is given on a Wednesday is for the following Monday. One-Pagers are due Fridays via Canvas.

Act I — Become a Writer · Aug 24 – Sep 23

Week	Focus	Reading
1 · Aug 24	Why we write; trust the gush	Edwards, “Who’s Cheating Whom?”; <i>WWM</i> Intro–ch2
2 · Aug 31	The notebook; writing place; privacy & redaction	Wiederhold, “How to Read a Blank Page of Writing”; <i>WWM</i> ch3–8
3 · Sep 9 (Wed only)	Voice print: rendering a person in their own voice	Daspit, “None of Us”; Romano, “My Father’s Voice” (audio); <i>WWM</i> ch9–10
4 · Sep 14	Show, don’t tell	J. Edwards, “Beyond Presence”; Chiang, “ChatGPT Is a Blurry JPEG of the Web”; <i>WWM</i> ch11–13
5 · Sep 21	Breaking the rules (Grammar B); Generation Loss lab ; the Look-Back	O’Hara, “Moviehouse Poems”; Lamott, “Shitty First Drafts”; <i>WWM</i> ch14–15

Act II — The Currere · Sep 28 – Oct 30

Week	Focus	Reading
6 · Sep 28	Launch the currere; the four moments; find your thread	Moore, “Starting the Conversation”; Currere Guidelines; a published currere (CEJ)
7 · Oct 5	Conference Day 1 ; storyboard six scenes across time	<i>WWM</i> ch18
8 · Oct 12	Render load-bearing scenes; break-a-rule workshop	—
9 · Oct 19	Read-aloud revision & peer review; Conference Day 2	<i>WWM</i> ch16–17
10 · Oct 26	Mentors & the synthetical close; author-page audio	<i>WWM</i> ch19; endings skim-menu (Edwards · Daspit · Romano, “The Anchor, the Bridge, the Lesson”)

Act III — Multimodal Research Project · Nov 2 – Dec 2

Week	Focus	Reading
11 · Nov 2	Launch the MRP; Topic Map; set up NotebookLM	Students' own gathered sources
12 · Nov 9	NotebookLM lab & the flattening demo; drafting genres	Students' sources
13 · Nov 16	Assemble the draft; peer review; artifact studio	Students' sources
14 · Nov 23	No class — Thanksgiving	Revise toward final
15 · Nov 30	Specific-over-generic revision; share-out (Wed, Dec 2); the Look-Back Letter	—
Wed, Dec 2	Writer's Notebook due , Look-Back Letter included — last class	—
Finals	Multimodal Research Project due Wed, Dec 9 — final piece, artifact, and reflective note (via Canvas)	—

In-class readings (poems)

Most sessions open with a poem — read aloud, talked about for ten minutes, then left to do its work. Nothing to prepare and nothing to turn in.

Week	Poet	Poem
1	Paul Laurence Dunbar	"We Wear the Mask"
2	Emily Dickinson	"I dwell in Possibility –"
2	George Ella Lyon	"Where I'm From"
3	Thomas Hardy	"The Voice"
4	Galway Kinnell	"Blackberry Eating"
4	Seamus Heaney	"Mid-Term Break"
5	Jim Daniels	"Short Order Cook"
5	Walt Whitman	"O Me! O Life!"
6	Emily Dickinson	"Tell all the truth but tell it slant"
6	Linda Pastan	"Ethics"
7	Robert Hayden	"Those Winter Sundays"
8	E. E. Cummings	"[since feeling is first]"
8	Li-Young Lee	"The Gift"
9	Sylvia Plath	"Metaphors"

Week	Poet	Poem
10	Walt Whitman	“Song of Myself, 51”
10	Robert Frost	“The Road Not Taken”

Deliverables and grading

The course is worth **200 points**. The grade rests on the three projects plus the writer’s notebook.

Deliverable	When	Points
Act I — One-Pagers		
OP1 — Why You Write	Fri Aug 28	10
OP2 — Writing Place	Fri Sep 4	10
OP3 — Voice Print	Fri Sep 11	10
OP4 — Show, Don’t Tell	Fri Sep 18	10
OP5 — Breaking the Rules	Fri Sep 25	10
Act II — The Currere		
Conference Packet	Sun Oct 4	5
Currere First Draft	Fri Oct 16	10
Draft Conference	Tue Oct 20	5
Currere Final Draft	Fri Oct 30	30
Act III — Multimodal Research Project		
MRP — Proposal	Fri Nov 6	5
MRP — Draft	Fri Nov 20	10
MRP — Final Draft	Wed Dec 9	35
All Term — Writer’s Notebook		
Writer’s Notebook	Wed Dec 2	50
Total		200

Grading scale

The grade is the total of the items above, out of 200 points. A student earns the grade in the highest row whose point figure they have reached. Every possible total lands in exactly one row, including totals with a fraction: 195.5 reaches 188 but not 196, so it is an A.

Grade	Points (at least)	Percent	Grade	Points (at least)	Percent
A+	196	98%	C+	154	77%
A	188	94%	C	148	74%
A-	180	90%	C-	140	70%
B+	174	87%	D+	134	67%
B	168	84%	D	128	64%
B-	160	80%	D-	120	60%
			F	below 120	below 60%

The Writer's Notebook

The notebook is where the everyday writing of this course lives. Students write in it in nearly every class and on their own, and turn the whole thing in on **Wednesday, December 2** — the last class meeting. The Look-Back Letter is written in that session, so the notebook is complete on the day it is handed over.

It is graded on **kept practice, not polish**: the point is that the student wrote, often, without stopping to fix or judge. No one red-pens a free-write. The target is **at least one entry per class meeting** — expect **20 or more** entries by December.

Into the notebook go: every **free-write**, including the Week 1 *why do we write?* baseline and the daily openers; in-class **quick-writes and exercises**; currere **gushes, brainstorm, and storyboard notes**; the research **topic map and source notes**; **responses to the readings**; and the Week 15 **letter back** to the Week 1 self.

Marking a passage in Journaler is note-taking: it keeps the passage and cites its page, but on its own it is **not an entry**. It becomes one when the student writes what they make of it — **My Progress** in Journaler lists every reading still waiting.

Timed One-Pager gushes do not go in the notebook. Each is submitted with the One-Pager it produced, on the second sheet of that PDF, together with the record of the writing session.

The polished projects are turned in separately — the notebook is the raw material behind them. It is kept in **Journaler**, which dates and numbers entries, builds the Contents list, and turns the whole thing in with one click.

This is also where attendance lives. There is no separate attendance grade in this course, because an entry per class session already ties the grade to showing up and writing.

Working with AI

AI is part of this course, and using it well is one of the things students are here to learn.

That is different from letting it do the writing. The policy follows the three acts.

- **Act I (One-Pagers).** Students draft in Journaler under a timer that locks editing while it runs. That timed, in-app session is the proof the writing is theirs. Pasting in outside or generated text is not permitted. After the timer, an AI reflection partner may ask about the *experience* of writing, never about the words themselves.
- **Act II (Currere).** AI is a studio partner for thinking and questioning. The currere is hand-written. AI does not draft the scenes or the close.
- **Act III (Research Project).** Students use AI as a grounded research partner and must **transform** what it produces. Raw, unedited AI output does not count as the student's work, and there is a cap on how much raw output a project may include. A short reflective note on how AI was used is part of the grade.

Disclosure is required everywhere. Every piece turned in carries a short note on how AI was used — what tool, for what, at which step. **Honest disclosure is never penalized.** Undisclosed or prohibited use is an integrity violation.

Policies

Accessibility and Student Disability Services

If you anticipate or experience barriers based on disability in relation to the course design, you are encouraged to connect with Student Disability Services (SDS) and request reasonable accommodation. SDS provides accommodations and services for students with a variety of disabilities, including chronic illnesses, psychological, medical, learning, physical, and sensory disabilities, amongst others. I invite you to speak with me regarding your access needs while contacting SDS to learn more about the affiliation process and procedures for requesting accommodations.

- Oxford Campus: SDS@MiamiOH.edu
- Hamilton Campus: RADS@MiamiOH.edu
- Middletown Campus: RADS@MiamiOH.edu

Current SDS affiliated students should request accommodations according to SDS procedure. You are strongly encouraged to request and discuss your accommodation needs during the **first 1–2 weeks of the semester.**

Miami University's recommended statement — Student Disability Services syllabus statements, <https://miamioh.edu/academic-programs/resources-services/student-disability-services/faculty-tools/syllabus-statements.html>

Title IX, and what I am required to report

Writing about your own life. You choose your own topics in this course, and much of what you write will draw on your own experience. What a finished piece shows is always your decision — see **Privacy** below. There is one limit I cannot set aside, and you should know about it *before* you write rather than after.

I am a mandatory reporter. If you write or speak about having experienced sexual violence — including rape, sexual assault, dating violence, domestic violence, or stalking — and indicate that it happened while you were a Miami student, Miami requires me as a faculty member to report it to the University's Title IX office. I cannot promise confidentiality, and I must pass on relevant details, including names, if I know them. Someone from the University will then contact you about accommodations, support services, and your options for holding the person who harmed you accountable. You are not obliged to respond to them or to take any further step.

If you would rather that not happen, talk to a confidential resource instead of to me.

These people can hear what happened without starting a report:

- **Women Helping Women** — 24-hour crisis line **513-381-5610** (call or text), toll-free **877-889-5610**. Campus advocate: **513-818-4894**, frieseo@MiamiOH.edu. Miami states that speaking with the campus advocate is private and **will not initiate a report** with the University.
- **Student Counseling Service** — **513-529-4634**, StudentCounseling@MiamiOH.edu, weekdays 8 a.m.–5 p.m. After hours, ask the university police dispatcher at **513-529-2222** for the on-call counselor.

If you do want to make a report, or to ask about University policy:

- **Title IX & Title VI Coordinator** — Danica Myers, Warfield Hall 017, **513-529-1424**, TitleIX@MiamiOH.edu. Reports may be made at any time, including outside business hours.
- **Office of Community Standards** — **513-529-1417** · **Dean of Students**, 110 Warfield Hall — **513-529-1877**
- **Police** — Miami University Police **513-529-2222** · Oxford Police **513-523-4321**

What Title IX is. Title IX makes violence, harassment, and discrimination based on sex and gender civil-rights offenses, subject to the same accountability and the same support as offenses against other protected categories such as race or national origin. Miami University prohibits sex discrimination and sexual misconduct, including harassment, domestic and dating violence, sexual assault, and stalking.

Contacts verified against Miami's Title IX statement and University Safety's resource page, July 2026.

Academic integrity

Your work in this course must be honest. Cheating, plagiarism, fabrication, unauthorized collaboration, and misrepresentation are prohibited and handled under Miami University's Academic Integrity Policy. Cite every source you use, **including AI assistance**.

Attendance

There is no attendance grade and I do not take roll. Attendance is already inside the assignments. The Writer's Notebook is graded on kept practice at roughly an entry per class session, the five One-Pagers are drafted in class under a timer, and most days are three to five short activities rather than a lecture. The notebook is the record, and the student keeps it, not me.

If you miss a session, the day's outline is on the course site. Do the writing and it counts, exactly as if you had been here. Journaler runs anywhere, and the timer that keeps a One-Pager draft honest works at your kitchen table as well as in 222 McGuffey.

What attendance actually affects, concretely:

- **The two conferences, 10 points.** Conference Packet in Week 7 and Draft Conference in Week 9 are one-to-one meetings about the currere. There is no version of these you can do alone. If you cannot make your slot, tell me and we will reschedule, but they have to happen.
- **Peer response and read-aloud revision,** Weeks 9 and 13. Your draft gets read by a person who is not you. That feedback shapes work that *is* graded, so missing it costs you indirectly even though the session carries no points of its own.
- **The Generation Loss lab** and the **share-out** on the last day. Both are things the room does together, and neither reproduces from an outline.
- **Your Writer's Notebook,** at roughly an entry per session. This one you *can* make up from that day's outline.

The pattern is simple: **if it involves other people, being here is the assignment. If it is writing, the writing is the assignment.**

If you know you will miss, message me beforehand. You do not owe me a reason. Nothing is deducted for an absence, so there is nothing to excuse and no proof to produce. If something serious is happening in your life, tell me and we will move your deadlines.

Late work

Anything may be up to 48 hours late. No penalty, no need to ask, and no explanation required. Submit it and move on.

If you need longer than that, email me. You will get it. I would rather read your real work a week late than a panicked version on time. There is nothing to prove and no documentation to produce.

One thing cannot slide, and for the same reason attendance matters: other people are waiting on it.

- **Drafts that go to a conference or a peer review.** Someone else has to read it, so it has to exist. If yours will not be ready, tell me before the session and we will find another use for the time.

The end of term has a hard edge, and it is a calendar, not a rule of mine. The Multimodal Research Project is due **Wednesday, December 9**. The 48-hour grace still applies, which carries it to **Friday, December 11** — but nothing goes past that. Grades are due to the university the following Tuesday and there is no room behind it.

Privacy

Everything on the public course site is **de-identified** — no student names, work, or grades. Much of what you write this term is about your own life. You choose what a finished piece shows: redact, blur, or code what stays private. **Withholding is part of the composition**, and you are graded on craft and judgment, never on candor or how much you reveal.

Your writing stays yours

Journaler runs entirely in your browser. Nothing you write is uploaded and there is no account and no server. Because of that, your work lives in one browser on one machine — use ↓ **Save my work** often and keep the file somewhere you own.

Student support

- **Howe Writing Center** — free, individualized help with writing at any stage, for any Miami undergraduate. <http://miamioh.edu/howe/>
- **Rinella Learning Center** — academic counseling, workshops, tutoring, and supplemental instruction. <https://miamioh.edu/student-life/rinella-learning-center/>
- **English Language Learner Writing Center (ELLWC)** — writing support for students whose first language is not English. <https://miamioh.edu/centers-institutes/english-language-learner-writing-center/>
- **Student Counseling Service** — therapy, workshops, and wellness programming. <https://miamioh.edu/life-at-miami/health-well-being/student-counseling-service/>
- **Office of Student Wellness** — health and wellness education, prevention, and resources. <http://miamioh.edu/student-life/student-wellness/>